

They go around with T-shirts that say, “I’m spending my kids’ inheritance.” Instead of taking care of grandchildren or helping their sons and daughters with the family enterprises, they retire to Florida, organizing their financial lives so their money lasts not a minute longer than they do. They grow old and lame and then expect special parking places. They spend their time playing golf, watching daytime TV, or pressuring their elected representatives to give them even more benefits.

The old have not merely abandoned the young to their own fate; they have stabbed them in the back. It’s bad enough that they use up all their own money. But they don’t stop there. They spend other people’s money, too. And then they spend money that hasn’t even been earned yet.

The biggest items in the U.S. federal budget, Social Security and Medicaid, benefit the graybeards, not the young. And the budget is so far out of whack that for every dollar of tax revenue, the feds spend \$1.60. That is to say, they add 60 cents that will have to be paid sometime in the future—most likely, by their own sons, daughters and grandchildren.

How lucky the next generation is! If a lack of money breeds tough self-reliance, the young in America must be the toughest generation ever. Not only do they have to pay their own way in the world, they’re also expected to shoulder a debt burden that would make break Atlas’s back. Their parents and grandchildren bequeath them public debt and unfunded obligations of more than \$200 trillion, according to Boston University professor Laurence Kotlikoff’s estimate.²

Forbes publishes a list of the world’s richest people. But suppose it published a list of the world’s poorest people. Who would it put on this list? Surely, America’s young people would lead the rankings. Each one is a slave, shackled to such a big ball and chain of debt he is lucky if he can still move.

It hardly seems fair.

Economist Robert Samuelson, writing in the *Orange County Register*, shares our opinion: “Whether our elected politicians will take back government from the AARP, the 40 million–member organization representing retirees and near retirees”⁸ is the big question for the 2012 budget debate. Obama’s budget proposals left Social Security and Medicaid untouched. Why? The greedy old geezers vote.